

BABY BOON Women carrying their babies who were part of a weight-gain programme at Nandarkhe village in Nandurbar, Sept. 13

MANDAR DEODHAR

sively breastfed for the first six months is 86.6, much higher than the national average of 63.7, according to the National Family Health Survey-5.

Then why is Nandurbar still faring so poorly in terms of nutrition? Minal Karanwal, project officer, Integrated Tribal Development Programme, says there is an urgent need to "bring science to the administration" in order to address this anomaly. For instance, milk transfer is important in breastfeeding. If a baby is not able to transfer (remove) milk from the breast due to issues with latching, the milk production decreases. "In Nandurbar, we are raising awareness about it," says Karanwal. The district took its first step in this direction in March this year, when Mumbai-based nutritionist Dr Rupal Dalal held a training session on breastfeeding for auxiliary nurse midwives (ANMs) and other village-level female health workers. Based on the response, the administration printed the material and produced videos in local tribal languages. The 1,200-odd CHOs, like Dr Kakuste, and their teams of ANMs were tasked with sharing such scientific concepts with new and soon-to-be mothers, during awareness sessions held at health subcentres and by visiting their homes. Six months later, weight gain being recorded among infants has been quite encouraging.

TRIBAL-DOMINATED NANDURBAR DISTRICT IN MAHARASHTRA SHOWS HOW SCIENTIFIC BREASTFEEDING CAN HELP INFANTS GAIN WEIGHT AND FIGHT MALNUTRITION

However, ensuring that the new mothers breastfeed their babies regularly and multiple times a day remains a challenge. As most of the women work in the fields, they leave their newborns at home. "We are working on a plan to increase the income of women," says Manisha Khatri, who took charge as the district collector last year. "If they are assured of a good income, they will be able to afford to lose some working days." The collector points to farming of strawberries, a novelty in Nandurbar, which she says has helped some farmers earn well. Another challenge is plugging "leakages" in the delivery of meals to children, pregnant women and lactating mothers through the district's 2,500-odd anganwadis. "We will integrate meal delivery at anganwadis with that at ashram schools," says Khatri. The latter are residential schools for tribal children that work under the collector's direct supervision, unlike the anganwadis that are monitored by zila parishads.

"We don't claim that we have succeeded in ending malnutrition. It is only a beginning. There is a long way to go," Khatri acknowledges, while adding that malnourishment alone is never the reason for an infant's death. "It is always combined with birth asphyxia, pneumonia, diarrhoea, sepsis, etc."

Only time will tell whether the Nandurbar experiment is a hit or a miss. But with the high court keeping tabs on steps being taken by the Maharashtra government to end malnutrition in the state's tribal areas, there is hope for healthy progress. ■